

FUTURE SKILLS SERIES

AI Literacy • Lesson 3 of 6

THE FACT DESK LESSON

Hallucination Hunters

Smooth is not the same as **true**.

Grades 6–8

45-min lesson

No prep • No devices needed



STUDENT SESSION • THE COMET

The Fact Desk



Name: _____ Class: _____ Date: _____

A note from Deja, the editor of The Comet, the school paper: "You're on the fact team. Three writers used an AI helper. Remember: AI guesses the most likely words — it does not check them — so it can be completely wrong and still sound sure. No story gets printed until you check it."

Desk words: run = it gets printed · clear = it passes the check · log = write it down · second source = a place to check that is NOT where you first saw the claim · "the ending still stands" = it is still true once the facts are fixed · stamp = your verdict box (RUN, FIX, or KILL) — check one · column = one writer's regular story

Your method, every draft:

- 1. **UNDERLINE** every checkable claim (names, dates, numbers, places, quotes).
- 2. **RANK** — write **C** above claims to CHECK, **S** above SAFE ones.
- 3. **LATERAL-READ** — leave the draft. Log a second source that could confirm each claim.
- 4. **VERDICT** — check a stamp, give your evidence, and say if the writer's ending still stands.

On the typeable PDF you can't underline. Copy each claim you'd CHECK into the table, and put your S-claims in the last row.

🔍 DRAFT #1 — PRIYA'S SCIENCE COLUMN, "MOON FACTS"

The Moon is Earth's only natural satellite. Astronauts first landed on the Moon in 1959, and Neil Armstrong was the first person to walk on its surface. By 1972, 12 people had walked on the Moon. On a clear night the Moon seems to shine because it produces its own light — which is why it's the brightest thing in the night sky.

Log your two riskiest claims — the two that would hurt The Comet most if they are wrong.

CLAIM I MARKED C (CHECK)		SECOND SOURCE: WHERE I'D CHECK IT	

☐	RUN — clean, print it	☐	FIX — correct it, then print	☐	KILL — cut the story
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Note to Priya — what's wrong, your second source, and does her ending still stand?

Need a start? What's wrong: _____. I would check _____.

THE FACT DESK LESSON • LESSON 3 OF 6

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A 45-minute AI fact-checking lesson. Students run the fact desk at the school paper — nothing gets printed until they clear it. They learn why AI can be confidently wrong, and the four-step method that catches it. Stands alone.

AT A GLANCE

TIME	MATERIALS	TECH NEEDED	PREP
45 min	The Fact Desk worksheet (3 pages, 1 per student) • Slides (optional) • board or chart paper for the RUN / FIX / KILL tally • pens or pencils	None — fully unplugged. Devices only add: desks can open the source they named and check the claims they marked C	Print worksheets. That's it.

OBJECTIVES — STUDENTS CAN...

- Explain why AI "hallucinates": it predicts likely words, so it can be confidently wrong. (*Exit #1*)
- Identify the checkable claims in a text (names, dates, numbers, places, quotes) and rank them by risk. (*Drafts 1–3, C/S*)
- Lateral-read a claim — name a second, independent source that could confirm it — and give an evidence-based verdict: RUN, FIX, or KILL. (*second-source column + stamp*)

STANDARDS ALIGNMENT

CCSS ELA RI.6.8

ISTE 1.3.b

ISTE 1.3.d

Full text + taught/assessed map for each code in the Teacher Guide.

DIFFERENTIATION

- Support:** Drafts #1–2 only, with the hint "two false facts per draft (plus a shaky ending)."
- Extension:** Write a smooth four-sentence passage with ONE planted error; trade desks and hunt.
- ELL:** Label the claim TRUE (name, date, number, place, quote) above each underline; partners read aloud; desk words are glued on p.1.
- No-device classrooms:** Built in — students name the source they would check. **With devices:** desks open that source and check the claims they marked C.

WARM-UP — THE STORY THAT ALMOST RAN (6 MIN)

Read this aloud, smooth and confident, like a news anchor. Then call the vote: "This is going in tomorrow's paper. Print it?"

"Our solar system has eight planets orbiting one star, the Sun. The closest planet to the Sun is Venus, which is also the hottest. Mars is called the Red Planet because rusty iron dust covers its surface. Saturn is famous for its rings — it is the only planet in our solar system that has them. Sunlight takes about eight minutes to reach Earth."

Expect most of the room to vote print. Reveal: **two sentences are false.** Mercury is closest to the Sun (Venus really is the hottest — the half-truth is what makes it slippery), and Saturn isn't alone: Jupiter, Uranus, and Neptune have faint rings too.

If the room votes **HOLD**: ask which sentence they doubt — most name Saturn and miss Venus. "One doubt is a start. The desk finds BOTH." If a kid names Venus instantly: "Write it down. We vote first, then we check." The second error usually slips past anyway.

Bridge (say it): "That sounded right because it was SMOOTH, not because it was TRUE. AI talks like that all the time — it predicts likely words; it doesn't check them. Today you're the fact desk: nothing gets printed until you clear it."

The three drafts, continued — true claims, safe to confirm: #1 — the Moon is Earth's only natural satellite; Neil Armstrong walked first; by 1972, 12 people had walked on the Moon. #2 — the Pacific is the largest ocean; the Nile flows north through Egypt and is one of the world's longest rivers; seven continents (seven in the model US schools use); Asia is the largest. #3 — the phonograph (1877) was the first machine to both record and play back sound; the Wright brothers made the first sustained, controlled powered flights in 1903 near Kitty Hawk, North Carolina — the widely accepted record (rival claims exist, so a desk that marks it C is doing the job).

KEY — "SECOND SOURCE: WHERE I'D CHECK IT" COLUMN

The ISTE 1.3.b item. Full credit: a specific KIND of source, independent of the draft and of the AI. Partial: "look it up online." No credit: asked the AI again; "Google" with no site named; the draft itself.

DRAFT	ACCEPTABLE SECOND SOURCES	WHAT FAILS
#1 Moon	A space-agency page (NASA) on Apollo 11 or the Moon; an encyclopedia entry "Moon"; a science textbook's astronomy chapter.	"Ask the AI if it's sure"; a video that repeats the claim; "Google" with no site named.
#2 Records	An atlas or globe; an encyclopedia entry on Everest or Australia; a geography textbook; the Australian government's own site.	A quiz site that copied the claim; a friend who "knows"; the draft itself.
#3 Inventions	An encyclopedia entry on Bell, Edison, or the telephone; a museum site (Smithsonian); a history textbook. For the quote: a quotation reference or a collection of Edison's writings — nothing turns up, so it has no source.	"It's in quotation marks, so it's real"; asking the AI "did Edison say this."

EXIT TICKET KEY

#1 — How can AI sound 100% sure and still be wrong? Full credit names the mechanism: AI predicts the likely next words and never checks them. Confidence is a writing style, not evidence. Accept "it guesses what sounds right" or "it's a smooth talker, not a fact-checker." Partial credit: "it makes mistakes" with no why.

#2 — A real checkable claim, a second source that is NOT where they first saw it. Full credit names a claim with a name, date, number, place, or quote in it AND a specific second source ("the NASA site, not the video that made the claim"; "a news site that didn't copy the first one"). Partial: "Google it" with no source named — or back: "Google shows you ten sources. Which one, and why that one?" No credit: "ask the AI again."

FULL STANDARDS TEXT

- **CCSS ELA RI.6.8** — Trace and evaluate the argument and specific claims in a text, distinguishing claims that are supported by reasons and evidence from claims that are not. Taught: Fact-desk method steps 1 and 4 (underline claims; test the ending). Assessed: the RUN/FIX/KILL stamp + note on each draft ("does the ending still stand?").
- **ISTE 1.3.b** — Students evaluate the accuracy, perspective, credibility and relevance of information, media, data or other resources. Taught: lateral reading, step 3. Assessed: the "Second source" column on each draft (key above) + Exit Ticket #2.
- **ISTE 1.3.d** — Students build knowledge by actively exploring real-world issues and problems, developing ideas and theories and pursuing answers and solutions. Taught: The Fact Desk activity — desks pursue verification and defend verdicts in "Verdicts out loud." Assessed: Exit Ticket #2 (a real claim from their own week, and where they would check it).

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